

TPN simulation: documentation

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January 13, 2025

1 Basic Structure

The simulation is called using the call

```
s1 = runTPNIIsimulation("simulationfile.txt", "apicalfile.txt", "basalfile.txt", ...  
"shuntfile.txt", "neuronfile.txt", "iineuronfile.txt", "weights1.txt", "network1.txt", .  
"externalinputs.txt") ;
```

where the filenames provide the configuration data for the network and neurons, as well as the external inputs. These files are all tab separated, with the first line giving the name of each element in the lines below. For each file, the basic purpose and first line is

simulationfile.txt defines the number of two point neurons, inhibitory interneurons, duration and time step. First line of file is N_TPNs (number of two point neurons) N_IIs (number of inhibitory interneurons) duration (in seconds) timestep (in seconds).

apicalfile.txt has one line for each two point neuron, defining the characteristics of the apical dendrite for that neuron. First line is n_apicalinputs tau_apical C_apical R_apical R_synap_dendrite C_apical_spine R_apical_spine R_synap_spine synapsemultiplier

basalfile.txt has one line for each two point neuron, describing the basal dendrite for that neuron. First line is n_basalinputs tau_basal C_basal R_basal R_synba_dendrite C_basal_spine R_basal_spine R_synba_spine synapsemultiplier

shuntfile.txt has one line for each two point neuron, describing both the apical and basal shunts for that neuron. First line is apicalshuntduration basalshuntduration noapicalshunts nobasalshunts

neuronfile.txt has one line for each two point neuron, primarily describing the threshold and the way it changes after a spike, as well as the refractory period and relative refractory period. First line is refractoryperiod relrefperiod thresh_leap thresh_decay thresh_value maxnospiques

ii neuronfile.txt has one line for each inhibitory interneuron, primarily describing the single compartment as well as the threshold and the way it changes after a spike, and the refractory period and relative refractory period. First line is n_synapses tau C R refractoryperiod relrefperiod thresh_value thresh_leap thresh_decay maxnospikes synapsemultiplier

weights1.txt describes the (initial) weights on each synapse. First line is neuron_type (TPN or II) neuron_number syn_type (for TPN neurons, A (= apical), B (= basal), AS (= apical shunt) or BS (= basal shunt), and for II neurons, S (plain additive synapse) syn_number weight

network1.txt defines the interconnection between the outputs from neurons (TPNs and IIs) and the synapses. First line is from_ntype (TPN or II) from_nno to_ntype (TPN or II) to_nno to_syntype (for target TPN, A for apical, B for Basal, AS for apical shunt, BS for Basal Shunt, and for target II, S) to_synno delay

externalinputs.txt defines the timing of the externally provided input spikes. First line is inputtype (A, B, AS, or BS, which imply that the input neuron is a TPN, or II when the input neuron is an inhibitory interneuron) Nno (the number of the neuron: note that TPNs and IIs both start at 1) time synapseno

The output from the call (*s1* above) is the list of spikes generated. Each spike is coded as (neuron_number time), where the neuron numbers start at 1, with TPNs preceding IIs.

The overall calling structure of the project is shown in figure 1.

Running the simulation involves calling *runTPNIIsimulation*. This function calls the functions (in order) *readnetwork*, *readapicalfile*, *readbasalfile*, *readshuntfile*, *readneuronfile*, *readexternalinput*, *readIIneuronfile*, *setupnetworkV2*, *setupinterconnection* to set the project network and its input up. To run the simulation, it then calls (once per *timestep*) *TPN_runstep* and *II_runstep* multiple times, once for each neuron. If any of these generates a spike, these are added to the appropriate set of input spikes. After the simulation completes, a graph of the spikes is drawn (using *spikeraster*), graphs of the activation and threshold for each neuron are drawn, and a list of spikes is returned,

2 Data structures

There are currently seven Matlab structures in this simulation, *simulation*, *neuron*, *targets*, *apical*, *basal*, *shunts*, *IIneuron*. These are described below.

2.1 Structure: *simulation*

This describes simulation-wide information and parameters. It has 5 fields:

N_TPNs number of two point neurons

N_IIs number of inhibitory interneurons

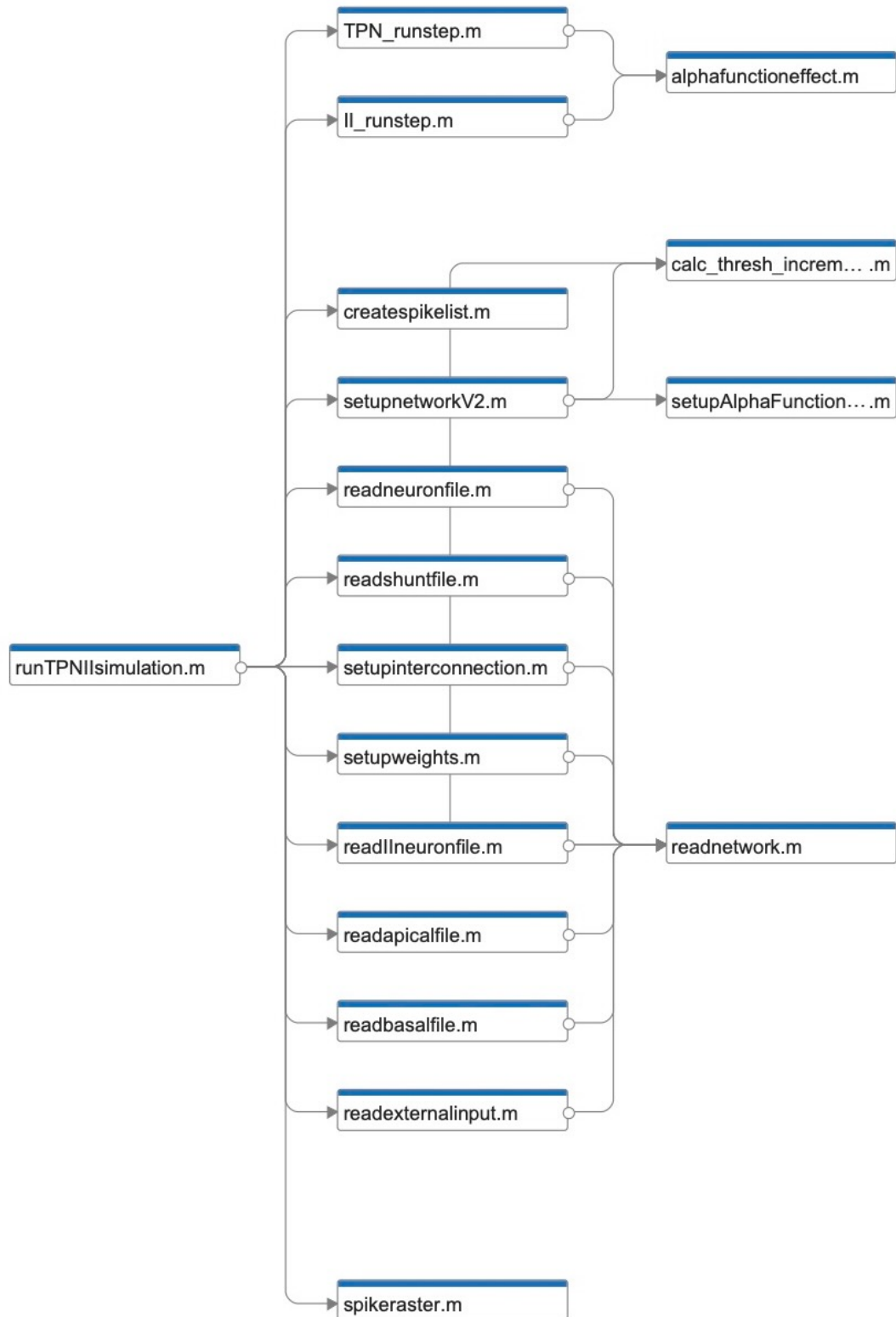


Figure 1: Overall calling structure of the functions within the project

duration duration of the simulation (seconds)

timestep simulation time step (seconds)

simlength duration of the simulation (time steps); calculated from simulation.duration and simulation.timestep

2.2 Structure: *neuron*

This describes information relevant to the two point neurons (TPNs). It is an array of structures, with one per TPN, It has 12 fields currently:

refractoryperiod refractory period of each TPN

relrefperiod relative refractory period of each neuron

thresh_leap amount by which the threshold increases (leaps) after a spike is generated

thresh_decay rate at which threshold decays after increasing

thresh_value initial value of the threshold

maxnospikes the maximum number of spikes that can be stored for this TPN

TP_threshold holds the threshold for the whole simulation duration for each TPN

targets structure holding information about the targets for the exon of this neuron (see below)

thresh_increment the incremental threshold added after a spike (computed from neuron.thresh_leap and neuron.thresh_decay as well as neuron(i).refractoryperiod, neuron(i).relrefperiod and simulation.timestep.

th_inc_length length of neuron(i).thresh_increment

spikes timing of spikes (in timesteps). Maximal number is neuron(i).maxnospikes

targets target for this TPN neuron's axon. Format (neuron type, neuron number, synapse type, delay (in seconds)).

2.3 Structure: *targets*

This is an array of structures inside each of the neuron(i) and IIneuron (i) structures, one per connection of the neuron's axon to another neuron. It has 4 fields:

t_ntype the type of neuron to which this axon is connected: TPN or II

t_nno the identity of the neuron to which the axon is connected

to_syntype the type of synapse to which the axon is connected (A, B, AS, BS, S)

delay the delay associated with this connection (in seconds)

delaysamps the duration in timesteps (calculated from duration above, and simulation.timestep.

2.4 Structure: *apical*

This is an array of structures, one per TPN, describing the apical area and apical spines. Each apical synapse works using the same values, except for the weight which is different for each synapse. Each structure has fields:

n_apicalinputs the number of apical inputs (synapses) on this neuron

tau_apical the time constant of the apical area

C_apical the capacitance of the apical area

R_apical the resistance of the apical area

R_synap_dendrite resistance of apical dendrite (apical to basal)

C_apical_spine the capacitance of the apical spine (for all the synapses)

R_apical_spine the resistance of the apical spine (for all the synapses)

R_synap_spine

synapsemultiplier used to allow weights to be in a unitary range, while making the voltages of an appropriate size.

apicalinputs the timing of the (external) apical inputs, in the form of (timestep, synapseno) repeated

apicalsynapseweights an array of weight values, one per apical(i).n_apicalinputs

apicalspikenos maximal number of external apical spikes

alpha_apical array providing the alpha function for (all the) apical synapses

apicalpostsynapse array (number of apical synapses (apical(i).n_apicalinputs) by simulation.simlength) recording postsynaptic apical activation

apicalfracleak fractional leak from apical area: set from simulation.timestep / (apical(i).R_apical * apical(i).C_apical)

apicalspinefracleak fractional leak from (all) apical spines: not used inTPN_runstep_v3, (set to 0),but planned to be used in v4.

2.5 Structure: *basal*

This is an array of structures, one per TPN, describing the basal area and basal spines. Each basal synapse works using the same values, except for the weight

n_basalinputs the number of basal inputs (synapses) on this neuron

tau_basal the time constant of the basal membrane

C_basal the capacitance of the basal area

R_basal the resistance of the basal area

R_synba_dendrite resistance of basal dendrite

C_basal_spine the capacitance of the basal spine

R_basal_spine resistance of basal spine

R_synba_spine resistance of basal dendrite (basal to apical)

synapsemultiplier used to allow weights to be in a unitary range, while making the voltages of an appropriate size.

basalinputs the timing of the (external) basal inputs, in the form of (timestep, synapseno) repeated

basalsynapseweights the basal synaptic weights, one per basal(i).n_basalinputs

basalspikeno maximal number of external basal spikes

alpha_basal array providing the alpha function for (all the) basal synapses

basalpostsynapse array (number of basal synapses (basal(i).n_basalinputs) by simulation.simlength) recording postsynaptic basal activation

basalfracleak fractional leak from basal area: set at simulation.timestep / (basal(i).R_basal * basal(i).C_basal)

basalspinefracleak fractional leak from (all) basal spines: not used (set to 0) in TPN_runstep_v3, but planned to be used in v4.

2.6 Structure: *shunts*

This is an array of structures, one per TPN. It describes the different shunting synapses, which may be apical or basal. These multiplicative synapses act on the summed activation.

noapicalshunts : number of apical shunting synapses

nobasalshunts : number of basal shunting synapses

apicalshuntinputs : actual apical shunt inputs, in (time synapse_number) format, external and internal

basalshuntinputs : actual basal shunt inputs, in (time synapse_number) format, external and internal

apicalshuntweights : weights for apical shunt: $0 \leq \text{value} \leq 1$ where 0 has no effect

basalshuntweights : weights for basal shunt: $0 \leq \text{value} \leq 1$ where 0 has no effect

apicalshuntduration : time that apical shunt is active for (in seconds): shunting effect is spread over this duration

basalshuntduration : time that basal shunt is active for (in seconds): shunting effect is spread over this duration

2.7 Structure: *IIneuron*

This structure describes the inhibitory interneurons (IIs), which are basically leaky integrate and fire neurons. There is an array of these structures, one per II.

refractoryperiod : II LIF refractory period, during which it cannot fire

relrefperiod : relative refractory period, during which threshold is elevated

C capacitance of single compartment

R leakage resistance of single compartment

II_threshold : array to hold actual threshold

thresh_leap : amount by which threshold increases after firing (and after refractory period)

thresh_decay rate at which the elevated threshold decays

thresh_value initial threshold value

th_increment : array to hold threshold increment

th_inc_length length of th_increment

spikes array of spike times

spikecount number of spikes produced

maxnospike maximum number of spikes for this neurons

tau used in setting up alpha function

alpha_synapse : array from alpha function (which is the same for each synapse, thus for each neuron)]

activation array to hold activation

inputs the (external, currently) inputs to this II neuron (format: (time, synapse number))

n_synapses number of synapses on this II neuron

alpha_synapse alpha function for all the synapses on this II neuron

weights the weights on each synapse (should be n_synapses long)

fracleak leakage per time step, calculated from C, R and simulation.timestep.

targets target for this II neuron's axon. Format (neuron type, neuron number, synapse type, delay (in seconds)).

3 Spike format

Spikes may be externally or internally generated. External spikes are predefined, and arrive from outside the simulation, and are listed in the file *externalinput.txt*. Internal spikes arise when a neuron fires: each firing may create a number of spikes on at different synapses, on different neurons. These are added to the appropriate part of the appropriate structure.

3.1 External spike inputs

External inputs may be for either a TPN or an II. Those for a TPN may be apical, basal, apical shunting or basal shunting. There is, however, only one type of synapse on an II. Internally, they have the format (N_i time S_i), where N_i is the neuron number, time is the time of arrival of the spike (in seconds), and S_i is the synapse number. These should be in time order (although there may be more than one spike at any specific time). Spikes are read from a tab-separated file into a MatLab table and thence to a structure by the function *readexternalinput*.

3.2 Internal spikes

Internal spikes arise from spikes on any of the neurons. These will be coded internally as (target_type N_i time S_i) where target_type may be apical, basal, apical shunting, basal shunting or inhibitory interneuron. Each spike may arrive at a number of different synapses, on a number of different neurons, each with their own delay.

4 Major functions

The major functions within this simulation are *TPN_runstep*, *II_runstep*. Each of these runs one neuron for one timestep.

5 Operation

5.1 Synapse on a spine (on a TPN) (applies to both apical tuft and basal dendrites)

Logically, a presynaptic pulse arrives at a spine synapse, and results in the transfer of charge to the dendrite. This transfer of charge takes place over time, and is represented by the alpha function. The total charge is proportional to the weight associated with the synapse.

Currently (TPNrunstep.v3) the alpha function is added to the depolarisation (voltage? current?) of the spine, and then these are summed to give the apical current. This is probably not the best idea, even if it basically works!

We could consider the synapse to be transferring charge to the dendrite to which it is attached. So we could just multiply the alpha function by the weight to get the time course of this charge, and simply add the charge up at the dendrite (i.e. consider the dendrite as a point).

While this is simpler, it loses the advantage of the isolation of the spine. Alternatively, consider the charge incoming at the spine (which is proportional to the weight): this takes place over time in a way characterised by the alpha function which describes the conductance and hence the current. This charges up a spine capacitance ($C_{\text{apical_spine}}$) (with leakage resistance ($R_{\text{apical_spine}}$)) and allows a voltage to be recorded at the spine over a time period rather longer than the alpha function. This voltage causes a transfer of charge (current over time) through the resistance of the body of the spine ($R_{\text{synap_dendrite}}$) into the dendrite. When we come to consider adaptivity, we would then have a voltage at the spine (where adaptation take place) as well as the voltage at the dendrite enabling a more nuanced approach to changing the weight (or other characteristic of the spine base synapse)¹.

Matlab functions have been written to help accomplish this in TPNrunstep.v4: *setupAlphaFunction.m* (used to create the alpha function as an array which sums to 1, appropriately when the alpha function describes the post-synaptic voltage, and used in v3), and *setupAlphaFunctionV2.m* (which is used in v4, where the alpha function describes the transfer of charge through the synapse, so instead of summing to 1, the

¹The spine itself is isolated from the dendrite, but adaptation at the spine has local values of both the depolarisation at the spine and at the dendrite to which it is attached. Thus (for example) a burst arriving at the spine synapse might cause a large increase the depolarisation at the spine, which could result in conformational (or other) longer term changes at the spine, This might be modulated by depolarisation at the dendrite (base of the spine).

integral (sum) of the function over time is 1

$$\sum_{i=1}^{\text{length}(\alpha)} (\alpha(i)\Delta t) = 1 \quad (1)$$

and implemented in `alphafunctioneffect.m` (used in V4 to calculate the voltage effect on a spine of the charge coming in, time step (`simulation.timestep`) by time step, considering the capacitance and leakage resistance at the spine containing the synapse).

While the units are now correct (the incoming charge is current times time, and the outgoing voltage is the voltage on a capacitor in response to this charge), we need to think about the actual size of these values. The alpha function integrates to 1, so that the total incoming charge is weight coulombs. Given a weight of (say) 3, and a capacitance of 10^{-8} farads (i.e. $0.01\mu F$), this leads to a voltage of

$$\frac{1}{C} \sum_{i=1}^{\text{length}(\alpha)} (\alpha(i)\Delta t)w \quad (2)$$

i.e. $3 * 10^8 v$, independent of the timestep, and the leakage is set to 0, or rather less (about $1.2 * 10^8$, for a leakage of 0.01) if not.

5.2 Apical tuft to apical dendrite

The voltage on each spine-based dendrite passes a current through a resistor (`R_synap_dendrite`) to the dendrite, where this results in an increase in the voltage across a capacitance (`C_apical`), which is concurrently being discharged by a leakage resistance (`R_apical`). The voltages from the different spines are summed. The apical dendrite is currently considered as a point.

If we need to subdivide the different inputs to the apical dendrite, and deal with them in a more complex way than simply summing them, then we will need to introduce some geometry to the apical dendrite.

5.3 Basal dendrite

The charges arriving from the spine-based dendrites are summed: again there is a capacitance (and a leakage resistance) associated with the basal dendrite (which is considered as a point currently). If we need to subdivide the different inputs to the basal dendrite, and deal with them in a more complex way than simply summing them, then we will need to introduce some geometry to the basal dendrite.

5.4 Oblique dendrite: from tuft to basal area

This transfers the charge (voltage?) from the apical area to the basal area, enabling the apical area to influence the basal area, and hence the possibility of spike production. The

details of how this happens are not currently clear, and we characterise this using the equation from Reza and Ahsan.

$$\text{ahactiv}(t) = (B(t)^2 + 2B(t) + 2A(t)(1 + |B(t)|)) \quad (3)$$

where $B(t)$ is the basal activation (voltage) and $A(t)$ is the apical activation (voltage), and $\text{ahactiv}(t)$ is the axon hillock activation. This results in a spike if the threshold is exceeded. On a spike being generated, the threshold is set to ∞ for the refractory period, then falls to the initial threshold + threshold_leap, and then exponentially decreases towards the initial threshold.

5.5 Inhibitory Interneuron (II)

Inhibitory interneurons are simple leaky integrate-and-fire neurons, characterised by a single compartment with a capacitance C and leakage resistance R . Incoming spikes a synapses release charge according to an alpha function and weight, and this charges the capacitor C (while leaking through R), resulting in a voltage across the capacitor. These voltages are summed, and a spike is caused when the threshold is exceeded. As for the TPN axon hillock, on a spike being generated, the threshold is set to ∞ for the refractory period, then falls to the initial threshold + threshold_leap, and then exponentially decreases towards the initial threshold.

6 Spikes and their targets

When a neuron spikes, the spike is transferred , with a delay, to 0 or more synapses. This is defined in the targets element of the neuron (i.e. the target element of the neuron structure for TPNs, and the target element of the *IIneuron* for inhibitory interneurons). This element has the structure *targets*, described above.

When a spike occurs, the spike is added to the spikes list for the target neuron: this is *apicalinputs* in the *apical* structure, *basalinputs* in the *basal* structure, and *inputs* in the *IIneuron* structure. The list of incoming spikes is sorted into time (in *timesteps*) order. Currently, no differentiation is made between predefined external spikes and those incoming from other neurons. Indeed the same synapse may receive inputs from both external spikes and those from any of the other neurons. Whether this happens depends on the predefined external spikes and the content of the file from which the targets are read (targets.txt currently).

6.1 Adaptation

We propose to use STDP adaptation on the spiny additive/subtractive synapses of the TPN. Elsewhere, this is probably inappropriate, but whether and how adaptation should take place on other synapses is not yet decided.

7 Testing and setting of parameters

Without testing, one cannot be sure that the system is behaving properly: indeed, even with testing one cannot prove this, but testing certainly improves belief that the system is behaving appropriately.

Basic functionality testing with small numbers of neurons: working.

Altered the time-step in simulationfile.txt from 0.0001 to 0.0005, and to 0.00002: minimal change in outputs: working